

THE KEY HURDLES

ANTI-INCUMBENCY: KCR is seeking a third consecutive term since first coming to power in the newly-created state of Telangana in 2014

OPPOSITION CHALLENGE: A resurgent Congress after the Karnataka win, and an aggressive BJP trying to expand footprint, coupled with dissatisfaction within

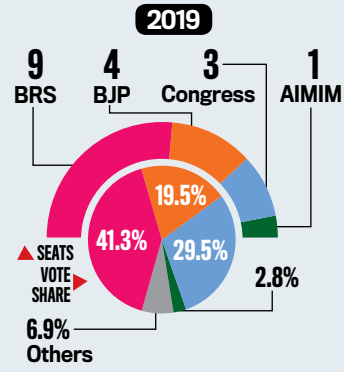
TICKET ALLOCATION: Balancing aspirations of party loyalists, next-generation leaders and Congress turncoats a challenge

GRAFT ALLEGATIONS: Many BRS legislators face allegations of taking 'cuts' from beneficiaries of welfare programmes

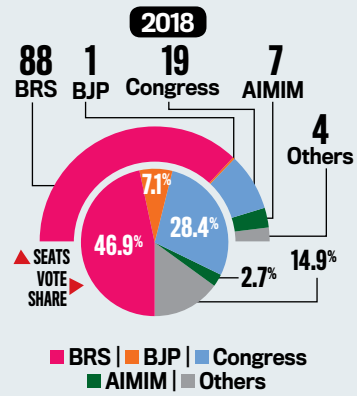
CASH CRUNCH: Even as KCR plans to announce poll sops to increase the ambit of beneficiaries, he has been forced to put the extension of existing schemes on hold

POLL POSITION

LOK SABHA ELECTION
Total seats: 17



ASSEMBLY ELECTION
Total seats: 119



NATIONAL PLAN

- KCR believes that by consolidating his party's position in other states, he will have better leverage at the national level
- Gaining a head start, the BRS has enlisted four former MPs and nine ex-MLAs in neighbouring Maharashtra
- KCR plans to field contestants in 27 of the 48 seats in the state, hoping to gain support of those disillusioned by the rift-ridden NCP and Shiv Sena
- Madhya Pradesh, Odisha and Andhra Pradesh are also on KCR's radar. But identifying constituencies is a work in progress
- But before all that, it's the outcome of the Telangana assembly polls that will determine the role the BRS can play nationally

Several BRS legislators face accusations of taking 'cuts' from beneficiaries of welfare programmes, including the flagship Dalit Bandhu and 2BHK housing schemes, so much so that it prompted KCR to warn them to be ready to face the sack, during the party plenary on April 27. Not willing to let the Opposition rake up the issue, the KCR government ensured that the newly appointed state BJP chief G. Kishan Reddy could not lead a delegation to an incomplete 2BHK apartments site on the outskirts of state capital Hyderabad on July 20. Reddy, who had just landed from Delhi, was stopped by the police on an arterial road near the airport, where he ended up sitting on a dharna to protest his "detention".

"KCR is sitting in Pragati Bhavan (his official residence and principal workplace) and muzzling the Opposition voice," Reddy said on assuming charge as the Telangana BJP president the following day, and went on to issue a warning. "We will usher in a 'bulldozer' government against corruption." After a setback in the assembly election in neighbouring Karnataka, the BJP has realised that it needs to get aggressive in exposing KCR's failures if it wants to pose any serious challenge to him. If the BJP is upping the ante, even the Congress has been infused with fresh energy after its win in Karnataka. The rifts within the BRS don't help the party's cause either. For KCR, choosing the right candidates is also a major challenge. He is determined to field only those who can fund and run their own campaign. The BRS chief himself is toying with the idea of switching to the Peddapalli constituency, uncertain of notching a landslide victory in Gajwel, which he won by nearly 60,000 votes in 2018.

IF BJP IS UPPING THE ANTE, **CONGRESS TOO HAS BOUNCED BACK AFTER ITS WIN IN KARNATAKA.** BRS'S INTERNAL RIFTS HARDLY HELP ITS CAUSE

In at least 25 of the 119 assembly segments, BRS candidates had lost despite spending large sums on their campaigns in 2018. They are now insisting that the party give them another shot, but are facing competition from the Congress defectors who had beaten them in 2018 before switching to the BRS. Though KCR had a comfortable majority, winning 88 of the 119 seats in the previous election, he had